Epilogue

‘Of God, people have said that He had a son; of the
Prophet they have said that he was a sorcerer
Neither God nor the Prophet has escaped the slander of
men. Much less I!’

– Akbar in a letter to Abdullah of Turan, *Akbarnama*

‘In our free Hall, where each philosophy
And mood of faith may hold its own, they blurt
Their furious formalisms, I but hear
The clash of tides that meet in narrow seas, –
Not the Great Voice not the true Deep.’

– Alfred, Lord Tennyson, ‘Akbar’s Dream’

Akbar did not want to die. He practised ascetic austerities – eating little, and of a predominantly ‘Sufiyana’ diet that excluded meat, sleeping little, and hailing celibacy as a virtue: ‘Had I been wise earlier, I would have taken no woman from my own kingdom into my seraglio, for my subjects are to me in the place of children.’ In the eventuality that he must die, even if he lived 100, 200 or 1000 years, Akbar had shaved a spot on his head, believing that this provided for his soul to escape through his skull, and return to live another great emperor’s life.

Far from living several times the span of a normal life, as he had been promised, Akbar died at the unexceptional age of sixty-three; and, as far as we know, he has yet to return to rule the world. But the emperor who sought immortality had one last trick up his sleeve. He was a bibliophile, after all, and he knew that books last longer than any human life, any dynasty, any age.

In the late 1580s, Akbar commissioned histories. He asked his aunt, Gulbadan, to write her memoirs, he asked his father’s water-bearer, Jouher, and one of his old soldiers, Bayazid Biyat. And, of course, he asked Abul Fazl – who collected many of these other writings (Bayazid, in fact, dictated his history to one of Abul Fazl’s clerks), interviewed older relatives, attendants and the emperor himself, trawled through the annals of Central Asia, Persia and Hindustan, and produced one of the most monumental works of literature that exists in the world – not only an